anecdote, thus, has some underlying message. I have not dwelt too much, therefore, on the three years spent at the National Defence Academy, Khadakwasla, Pune, or of the year at the Indian Military Academy, Dehradun. Similarly, the years as a Young Officer (YO), learning the ropes of Regimental life. Each incident, I believe, is unique to my life, and perhaps not known even to my friends and colleagues, who have been part of or closely associated with my career in the Army.

When a person reaches the pinnacle of any organization, the Chief of Army Staff, in my case, everyone thinks that it was all smooth sailing. There is also a feeling that the rise through the hierarchy was aided by a little bit of *chamchagiri* (apple polishing) and toeing the party line: 'Yes Sir, No Sir, three bags full, Sir.' Nothing could be further from the truth, but I leave that for the reader to decide. I've had my share of ups and downs—on both the professional and personal fronts. We weathered these storms, and by we, I mean our family as a whole, and came out not only stronger but more empathetic with those who would have been similarly disadvantaged. These setbacks, in fact, made me a better person and allowed me to have a more compassionate view when confronted with the foibles and shortcomings of the officers and men under my command, at whatever rank I was at that point in time. As a newly commissioned officer, when I got lost in the deserts of Rajasthan, apart from the military lesson, it also made me realize that such things can happen to anyone, that we are all human and we will all make mistakes.

As mentioned earlier, the thought of writing a memoir was not on the to-do list. Moreover, was my story worth telling? When one joins the Army, one doesn't think that one will become the Chief. One is quite content to pass the promotion exam to the next rank. Most of what I have written is from

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